

M365 AGENT BUILDER · BUILD-ALONG

Build Your First AI Agent

A guided, no-code build inside the apps you already use

In this session you build a real AI agent, directly from within your Microsoft 365 apps, with no separate portal and no coding. Your agent acts as an **HR Policy Assistant**, helping employees find answers about leave, flexible working and company policies. Keep this guide open and follow along with your presenter. By the end you will have a live agent you can share with your team. A separate session covers Copilot Studio for more advanced builds; today is the simplest, fastest route, the M365 Agent Builder built into the apps you already use.

Presented by Josh Akajioyi & Brian O'Shea · Partner Solution Architects, Microsoft

Agent Builder vs Copilot Studio

Microsoft gives you two ways to build agents. Today focuses on the quickest way to get started, right inside your M365 apps.

This session

Microsoft 365 Copilot app / Teams

M365 Agent Builder. Low-code. Build directly inside Microsoft 365, in Teams or the M365 Copilot app. No separate portal needed.

Separate session

Covered separately

Copilot Studio. Full-featured builder with advanced topics, flows and connectors for richer, more customised agents.

Before We Start

Have these three things ready before the session begins:

- 1 A Microsoft 365 licence that includes Microsoft 365 Copilot. Open the Microsoft 365 Copilot app from your app launcher, or open Microsoft Teams. Your presenter will confirm access at the start. No Copilot licence? You can still take part: the grounding step (Steps 7 to 9) has a second path for you.
- 2 The sample HR policy document, northbridge-hr-policies.docx. Your presenter shares this in the Teams chat, so download it and save it to your desktop or OneDrive before the grounding step. Prefer to use your own company policy document? Bring it along instead.
- 3 A modern browser or the Teams desktop app. Microsoft Edge or Google Chrome work best.

PART 1 OF 7 · OPEN AGENT BUILDER IN M365

You do not need any external website. Agent Builder lives inside the Microsoft 365 Copilot app you already have.

1 Open the Microsoft 365 Copilot app

In Teams or your browser, open the Microsoft 365 Copilot app. Look for the Copilot icon in your app bar, or go to m365.cloud.microsoft. Sign in with your work account if prompted.

2 Find the Agents section

Look for the **Agents** tab or icon within the Copilot app and select it. This is where you discover existing agents and create your own.

Can't see Agents?

Check the left-hand panel, or the **More apps** (...) menu in Teams. Your IT admin may need to enable Agent Builder for your tenant. If you still can't reach it, let your presenter know.

PART 2 OF 7 · CREATE A NEW AGENT

3 Select Create agent

In the Agents area, find the **Create agent** or **+ New agent** button and select it to open Agent Builder.

4 Give your agent a name

Type a name that suits your use case. For today, try *HR Policy Assistant*, *Employee Handbook Bot*, or *Leave & Benefits Agent*. Add a short description, for example:

Description: I help employees find answers to HR and policy questions.

PART 3 OF 7 · WRITE YOUR AGENT'S INSTRUCTIONS

Instructions tell your agent how to behave: its purpose, tone, and any boundaries you want it to respect.

5 Open the Instructions field

In Agent Builder, find the **Instructions** box. This is the system prompt: it tells the agent who it is and how it should respond.

6 Write your instructions

Paste this example to get started, then adjust it to suit your organisation:

You are an HR Policy Assistant for [Company Name]. You help employees understand their entitlements and company policies.

Only answer questions based on the HR documents provided. If the answer is not in the documents, say so clearly and advise the employee to contact the HR team directly.

Keep answers accurate, concise, and professional.

Quick tip

Keep instructions short and specific. Two or three clear sentences often beat a long paragraph. Say what the agent should not do too, for example: do not speculate about individual employee situations, and do not give legal advice, always refer complex queries to the HR team.

PART 4 OF 7 · ADD KNOWLEDGE (GROUNDING)

Grounding is what makes the agent answer from your documents instead of guessing. How you ground depends on your licence, so this step forks into two paths. Follow the one that matches you.

Choose your grounding path

Path A · You have a Microsoft 365 Copilot licence

Steps 7 to 9 · ground the agent at build time, the standard route

- 1. Find the Knowledge section.** In Agent Builder, scroll to the **Knowledge** (or **Grounding**) section. This is where you add the content the agent draws from.
- 2. Upload the HR policy document.** Select **+ Add**, then **Upload a file** (or **SharePoint** if your policies live there) and add **northbridge-hr-policies.docx**. Using your own policy document? Upload it the same way.
- 3. Confirm it is connected.** You should see your source listed. The agent now searches this content when answering. You can add multiple sources for a richer agent.

SharePoint sites work best: the agent searches every document in the site automatically. Make sure documents hold real text, not scanned images.

Path B · No Copilot licence yet? Ground it in the chat

Instead of steps 7 to 9 · no Knowledge section at build time, so attach the handbook after you publish

- 1. Skip the Knowledge step for now.** Without a Copilot licence the Knowledge / Grounding section is not available while you build, so leave it and carry on.
- 2. Publish the agent first.** Finish the remaining steps and publish (Step 14), then open your agent from the Agents section of the M365 Copilot app.
- 3. Attach the handbook in the chat window.** In the message box, select the **attach** (paperclip) or **Add content** option and upload **northbridge-hr-policies.docx**. Then ask your questions; the agent answers against the file you attached in that conversation.
- 4. Re-attach for each new chat.** A file added this way stays for that conversation only. Start a new chat and you attach it again. For permanent, always-on grounding, move to Path A once a Copilot licence is in place.

Both paths get you to the same place today: an agent answering from your handbook. Path A bakes the knowledge in for everyone; Path B grounds per chat until a licence is available.

PART 5 OF 7 · ADD STARTER PROMPTS (RECOMMENDED)

Starter prompts are example questions shown when users first open your agent. They help people know what to ask and make the agent feel polished.

10 Find the Starter prompts section

Look for **Conversation starters** or **Starter prompts** in the builder, then select **+ Add** to create your first one.

11 Add two or three example questions

Write questions a real employee would ask. For example:

How much maternity leave am I entitled to?
Can I carry over unused annual leave?
What is the remote working policy?

PART 6 OF 7 · TEST YOUR AGENT

12 Select Preview or Test

Find the **Preview** or **Test** button in the builder. A chat window opens so you can talk to your agent before publishing it.

13 Ask it a question

Type a question related to something in your knowledge source, and try a few phrasings. Notice how it pulls answers from your document and cites the source.

Testing ideas • copy these into the chat

How do I report a sick day?

What is the company's remote working policy?

Does the company have an Employee Assistance Programme?

What is my annual training budget?

PART 7 OF 7 • PUBLISH AND SHARE

14 Select Publish

Select **Publish**. You can share it three ways: just with yourself to keep testing, with specific colleagues, or with your whole organisation (subject to admin permissions). Your agent then appears in the Agents section of the M365 Copilot app for everyone you share it with.

On Path B? This is your grounding moment

If you do not have a Copilot licence, publish first, then open the agent and attach **northbridge-hr-policies.docx** in the chat window (see Part 4, Path B) to start asking questions.

Tips & Troubleshooting

- Unexpected answer? Rephrase the question. Small wording changes can make a big difference.
- Make sure your document is text-based, not a scanned image. Word and PDF files with real text work best.
- Keep instructions concise. Start simple and add detail after testing.
- If a SharePoint site returns nothing, check that its documents are accessible to you.
- Do not aim for perfect today. This is your starting point, and you can keep refining after the session.

After the Session

- Share it with your wider team, gather feedback, and use what you learn to refine instructions and knowledge.
- Connect more SharePoint sites or documents to make the agent more knowledgeable.
- Attend the Copilot Studio session for advanced features: multi-step flows, custom topics, and external connectors.
- Talk to your IT admin about organisation-wide publishing so everyone can use your agent.
- Contact your Microsoft or Codec representative to discuss scaling and governing agents across your organisation.
- Keep learning: Microsoft Learn (learn.microsoft.com) has free guided paths on Copilot extensibility and agents.

You've built your first AI agent ✓

You now have a live M365 agent that can:

- Answer HR and policy questions from your handbook
- Greet users with helpful starter prompts
- Cite the source document in its replies
- Be shared with colleagues or your whole org

Thank you for joining today's session. Reach out to your Microsoft or Codec contact to keep the momentum going. Questions during the session? Use the Q&A panel in Teams. Follow-up: joshakajioyi@microsoft.com